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THEATRE ARTS

DIRECTING

The Director's Craft: From First Reading to Opening Night

A ZikShare teaching unit, written for this shelf

What a director actually does in the weeks between the first reading and the first performance, stage by stage, with the paperwork each stage produces.

WHAT THIS UNIT COVERS

- the first reading
- casting
- blocking
- rehearsal schedule
- technical rehearsals

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The director is the audience's first representative

A director is not the person who tells actors where to stand. The director is the person who holds one interpretation of the play steady while thirty other people make it, and who answers every question with the same answer for six weeks. That is the job: consistency under pressure.

The work divides into three unequal parts. Before rehearsals, the director decides what the play is about and who is in it. During rehearsals, the director builds the action with the actors. In the last week, the director hands the production over to the stage manager and the technical departments and protects it from panic. Most first-time directors spend almost all their time on the middle part and arrive at the last week unprepared.

The first reading is an argument you must be able to defend

Read the play three times before you say anything about it. First for the story, without a pencil. Second with a pencil, marking every time a character wants something and does not get it immediately. Third with the other characters in mind: what does each scene cost each person in it?

Then write one page, for yourself, that answers four questions. What happens? What is the play arguing? Whose play is it? What must the audience feel at the final curtain? If you cannot answer the third question, you do not yet know which part of the script you are directing, and every later decision will drift.

Casting is a design decision

Cast for the action, not the photograph. An actor who can want something badly on stage will hold an audience longer than an actor who looks right and plays an attitude. Read two contrasting scenes at the audition: one where the character is in control and one where they lose it. Watch what happens when the partner changes, not how well the speech is recited.

Keep a callback list larger than the cast. The hardest parts of a cast are usually the small roles with two scenes and no arc, and those are won by actors who listen.

Rehearsal: from the table to the run

A workable six-week schedule: week one at the table, on action and character; weeks two and three on blocking and scene work, in small chunks; week four on runs of each act; week five on full runs and detailed notes; week six in the theatre, on technical and dress rehearsals. In a three-week schedule, cut the table work to two days and accept that the acting will be found in performance.

Give notes on what the audience will see, not on what the actor feels. "You crossed on his line so we lost the letter" is a note an actor can use. "Be sadder" is not. Write every note down: if you repeat a note you have given before, the fault is usually in the instruction, not the actor.

Technical rehearsals are for the crew

A technical rehearsal is not a rehearsal of the play. It is a rehearsal of the cues, and it will be slow, and the acting will be bad, and that is normal. Stop for anything that could hurt someone or break something; let everything else run and fix it in notes. The dress rehearsal is the first performance: no stopping, no notes until the end, and a full company call afterwards.

After opening night

The director's work does not end at the first performance. Watch the show again in the second week, from different seats, with a notebook. Performances drift: a cross gets shorter, a pause gets longer, a scene speeds up because the actors are bored of it. Give a line note before the next performance, not a speech. Two or three specific notes will hold a show for a month; a general appeal to "keep the energy up" holds nothing.

Keep a production file: the script with the blocking, the cue sheets, the design drawings, the cast list, the photographs, the programme and the reviews. It is the evidence that the production happened, it is what you show the next venue, and it is what you will teach from in five years. Departments lose their history because nobody keeps the file.

Finally, write down what you would do differently. A director who cannot answer that question after a run has not been directing; they have been managing a series of emergencies. The answer is the beginning of the next production.

Working with actors who have done this longer than you

A student director often directs actors who are older, more experienced or more senior in the department. The authority does not come from the title; it comes from having done the work on the text. Come to every rehearsal with the scene read, the questions prepared and the blocking thought through, and the room will follow. Come unprepared and no title will hold it.

Ask, do not instruct, when the question is about the actor's process: "what is she trying to get from him here?" is a better note than "play it angrier". Keep instruction for the things that are yours - space, tempo, the shape of the scene - and keep the actor's process theirs.

Exercises

1. Take a ten-minute scene and write, for each character, one sentence beginning "I want". Compare with a partner; the scenes that fail usually have two characters wanting the same thing in the same way.
2. Block the same scene twice, once with the actors far apart and once with them close, and describe how the meaning changes.
3. Draw up a six-week rehearsal schedule for a full-length play with a cast of eight and a two-week get-in. Mark the day you stop giving line notes.

Where to read more

Peter Brook, The Empty Space (1968)

Harold Clurman, On Directing (1972)

William Ball, A Sense of Direction (1984)

Katie Mitchell, The Director's Craft (2009)

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